

our first year ever not working as independent contractors in some capacity, and I was experiencing the reality of my illiteracy in this new tax terrain. Now I know. Now I can **respond** by course correcting for next time and turn around and inform others so they don't have to experience the same thing. Hey, I'm starting to feel more in control and empowered in my situation. I'm not feeling as embarrassed. Maybe I will write about this in my book (lol).

It was from this place that I could then rework my catastrophizing and overgeneralizing inner thoughts and outward decisions. I found myself grateful that we did have the money to cover the expense. It was a lot, and it took us time to recover, but we were in a much different place than five years prior. It didn't ruin us. I was glad for a helpful accountant who didn't shame us but instead assisted us (and kept us out of tax prison . . . that's a thing, right?). I was glad for a community I could make mistakes in front of, a group of friends who had my back (including our readers and listeners!) who modeled grace and were full of encouragement on this journey where none of us are doing it perfectly!

And suddenly I wasn't trapped in my situation. I was moving forward with full awareness of my reality, a plan of attack in place, and thoughts that weren't debilitating. Curiosity helped me to manage myself in the midst of something really stressful and overwhelming and make important shifts where needed.

It was in this place of action that I felt the most relief within my circumstances. We were able to make the decision to cut back on eating out, a discretionary spending area where Eric and I are prone to indulge. Instead, we cooked at home more and put that money toward "replenishing the coffers," as I called it. I felt good about this course correction and our ability to change the trajectory of our situation. We also adjusted our tax withholdings so we would not find ourselves in this place again.

The freedom and control I was able to find over a stressful financial situation felt empowering. Curiosity helped me to be kind to myself and find real solutions.